CHEAT SHEET · USING CLAUDE EFFICIENTLY

# Claude Projects: set it up once, get better answers in every chat

**Try it yourself**

Scan for the kit: this sheet, instructions + 4 context files (folder Project-organizer).
`github.com/niluia/claude-kit-`

## 1 · What a project is made of

| | |
|---|---|
| **Instructions** | Rules for every chat here: role, goal, format. The only place rules work. |
| **Context** | Your files, shared by all chats. Watch the capacity bar. |
| **Memory** | What Claude learns here; kept separate from other projects. |
| **Chats and tasks** | Each chat starts fresh: it sees all of the above, not other chats. |

Outside projects: profile instructions (every chat) and Styles (tone). Claude can't see the project name or description.

## 2 · Instructions in 7 blocks

`<role>` who Claude is here; who you are
`<goal>` the one aim + what success looks like
`<audience>` who reads the output, what they know
`<knowledge_map>` each Context file + when to use it
`<working_rules>` "Do X, because Y"
`<output_format>` length, structure, an example
`<ask_and_verify>` ask first, name sources, log decisions

Start short. Add a rule only after a real failure.

## 3 · Rules Claude follows well

**Give the reason.** "Cite only papers with a DOI, because one fake citation discredits the thesis" beats "no fake papers".

**Say what to do.** "Write in flowing prose" beats "don't use bullets".

**Stay calm.** Plain rules beat "CRITICAL / MUST", which get over-applied.

## 4 · Context files that work

- Few, small, clean files. Markdown beats messy PDFs and slide decks.
- Name by content: `review-protocol.md`, not `Final_v2 (copy).pptx`
- No duplicates or old versions: they compete with each other.
- Keep a `decision-log.md`: the memory between chats.
- A file named "instructions" is still just reference, not rules.

## 5 · Try it: ask the same question twice

Ask in a plain chat, then in your project: *"Find me 10 key papers for my literature review on [topic] and summarise them."* Tick what each answer did.

| Did the answer… | Plain chat | Project |
|---|---|---|
| ask what you need before starting? | ☐ | ☐ |
| stay inside your scope (years, sub-topic)? | ☐ | ☐ |
| give a working DOI or link for every paper? (click 3) | ☐ | ☐ |
| use your table format, ready to paste? | ☐ | ☐ |
| judge each paper by your inclusion criteria? | ☐ | ☐ |
| name its sources and suggest a decision-log entry? | ☐ | ☐ |

## 6 · Recipe: a literature-review project

1. **Instructions:** 7 blocks + "never invent papers; check every DOI".
2. **Context:** `research-brief · review-protocol · paper-log · decision-log`
3. **Search:** "Search string for Scopus from my protocol."
4. **Screen:** paste an abstract: "Include or exclude? Which criterion?"
5. **Save back:** new rows to paper-log, decisions to decision-log.

## 7 · Daily habits

- **Edit, don't append:** fix your message and regenerate.
- **Summarise and restart** when a chat gets long or drifts.
- **Save back** plans and decisions to Context.
- **Quote, then answer** for long documents.
- **Debug:** "Which files can you see?" Test new instructions in a new chat.

### Starter prompt: let Claude write your instructions

```
I want a Claude Project for [my aim]. Interview me first, one question at a time (max 8). Then write instructions in tagged sections: role, goal, audience, knowledge_map, working_rules, output_format, ask_and_verify. Under 300 words, a reason for every rule. Finally, list 3-5 Context files to create.
```

Sources: Claude Help Center (support.claude.com) · Anthropic prompting best practices and context-engineering guides · [Presenter / course]